permit any other foreign state to interfere with the territory or internal administration of Tibet.'

This complicated milieu was to hold good till 1947 with some differences arising over the North Sikkim plateau. With the departure of the British from the subcontinent, Nepal, Sikkim and Bhutan retained their independence and sovereignty.

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The Bhutan-Tibet border follows natural features—the watershed of the Chumbi Valley in the northwest and the crest of the Great Himalayan Range of mountains to the north. It was only in the mid-eighteenth century that Bhutanese delegations to the Dalai Lama came into contact with the Chinese representatives in Lhasa, prior to which there never was a tributary relationship with Peking. Relations with Tibet itself, never particularly good, were strained considerably when Bhutan sided with Britain in the early 1900s. Trying to secure its southwestern flank against increasing foreign aggression, China claimed a vague suzerainty over Bhutan in the period just before the Chinese Revolution of 1911. The new Republic of China let the claim lapse, however, and it was never again raised publicly.

Tension in Bhutan-China relations increased with the Chinese occupation of Tibet in 1951 and again rose with the anti-Chinese revolts in eastern and central Tibet between 1954 and 1958. The massive Tibetan uprisings in 1959 and the flight to India of the Dalai Lama, as well as the heightened presence of Chinese forces on the ill-defined frontier, alerted Bhutan to the potential threat it faced, and its representative in Tibet was withdrawn. Included in the territory occupied by the PLA were the eight western Tibetan enclaves administered by Bhutan since the seventeenth century. New Delhi intervened with Peking on behalf of Thimphu regarding the enclaves, but the Chinese refused to discuss what it considered a matter between China and Bhutan. Another problem with China emerged at this time as the result of the flight to Bhutan of some 6,000 Tibetan refugees. The spectre of renewed Chinese claims to Bhutan, Sikkim, and Nepal was raised after China published a map in 1961 that showed alterations of traditional Sino-Bhutanese and other Himalayan borders in Peking's favour.